Unit 2 Writing an Essay

Introduction

This unit discusses essay writing. It further attempts to give you step-by-step insight into how an academic essay ought to be tackled. This unit meshes well with the first unit of this module. It is our hope that you will use the knowledge gained in unit 1 in order to come up with good essays that demonstrate originality.

Areas of emphasis

- definition of an essay
- parts of an essay
- stages in the essay writing process
- types of essays



Key words

- essay, introduction, body, conclusion, prewriting, drafting, revising, editing, expository, descriptive, argumentative

Prerequisite knowledge

It is very likely that you have written essays before. If not, definitely you have come across essays, read them or probably analysed them. More importantly, in our previous unit, we talked about how you can acknowledge information when writing essays. This knowledge is very important and it forms the bedrock for your understanding of this unit.



Learning outcomes

By the end of this unit, you should be able to:

- define the term essay
- write appropriate thesis statements
- write good body and conclusion of essays
- describe different types of essays
- apply the stages of essays writing.

Resources needed

- any text book containing sample essays
- pens and sheets of paper

- newspapers

2.0 Definition of an essay

In this unit, we will define an essay as a *group of paragraphs that support a controlling idea called a thesis.* What is coming out clearly here is that an essay has a couple of paragraphs put together in order to convey ideas. If someone writes on a topic in less than two sentences that does not constitute an essay. Essay paragraphs are composed on a specific topic in order to come up with ideas that are properly organised, nicely written and professionally presented.

2.1 Parts of an essay

The Greek philosopher Aristotle likened an essay to an animal. He contended that any essay has head, body and tail just like an animal has. In his words, the head of an essay is the introduction, the body is the actual body where your facts are properly explained and the tail denotes the conclusion. In line with this analogy, you should always remember that an essay must have an *introduction, body* and *conclusion.*

2.1.1 The introduction

This is the introductory paragraph of an essay. Sentences put in an introduction aim at attracting the reader's interest as such deliberate effort needs to be made so that readers' attention will be properly grabbed. Within the introduction, you find a *thesis statement*. This is the controlling statement that will be developed in the essay. In other words, a thesis refers to a statement or opinion that is discussed in a logical way and presented with evidence in order to prove that it is true. It constitutes the main idea in your piece of writing. The thesis statement consists of a *subject* and a *treatment.* The subject is what you intend to write about and it indicates the general area to be dealt with in your essay. The treatment refers to what you intend to do with the subject. Let us have an example that sheds more light on these two concepts:

Playing soccer is a worthwhile career in this modern age.

The above thesis statement can be analysed as follows:

- Playing soccer: **subject**
- Is a worthwhile career in this modern age: **treatment**

If you were to write an essay on the above topic, you were supposed to talk about soccer and you would certainly explain how today's soccer is profitable in comparison with soccer that was played several years back.

In a nutshell, the thesis statement:

- Tells the reader how you will interpret the significance of the subject matter under discussion.
- Is a road map for the paper. It is a guide that gives readers a preview of what to expect from the rest of your essay.
- Directly answers the question asked of you.
- Is usually a single sentence somewhere in your first paragraph that presents your argument to the readers. The rest of the paper, the body of the essay, gathers and organises evidence that will persuade the reader of the logic of your presentation.

 **Activity 1**

Think about any statement of your choice and identify subject and treatment.

If you got the above exercise right, it means you have a springboard that will assist you to write essays.

2.1.1.1 Sources of **theses**

You can get a thesis from:

a) Choosing your own thesis. This is arrived at after lengthy thinking.
b) An assignment given to you by your lecturer. Generally lecturers will give you a thesis statement on which you will be required to advance some arguments.
c) An examination question. Sometimes, you get thesis statements from examination questions that require you to supply essay answers.

2.1.1.2 Writing the thesis

Writing a good thesis starts with sound thinking. Before you develop an argument on any topic, you have to collect and organise evidence, look for possible relationships between known facts (such as surprising contrasts or similarities), and think about the significance of these relationships. Once you do this, you will probably have a "working thesis," a basic or main idea, an argument that you think you can support with evidence but that may need adjustments along the way. If this task is done properly, you are likely to come up with an interesting subject and a well-defined treatment.

A well-defined treatment is one that can be developed with supporting information and gives you just the right amount of information that fully supports your controlling statement. You should exercise care when choosing a thesis to ensure that your thesis is not vague, too, broad or too narrow. Let us look at this in depth:

- **Vague thesis – Private Schools *(Subject)* are good institutions *(Treatment).*** This thesis is vague because the treatment is so general. It does not really give us an impression of what we are looking for when we say "good". As a result if we were to write an essay based on this, we will certainly lack direction. Worse still, the concept of 'good' is subjective and difficult to perceive when advancing our arguments.

- **Better thesis - Private Schools produce better MSCE results than Government Institutions.** We are saying that this thesis is better because it is focused as a result our essay is going to elucidate how private schools perform well compared with government institutions.

- **Too broad a thesis – Private Schools (*Subject)* have many problems (treatment)**. This thesis is too broad because the treatment is open-ended and generic.
- It does not limit us on how many problems we should tackle in our essay as a result we may be left in dilemma - whether to write a short essay or an extremely lengthy one. A good thesis should strive to give a hint of what the writer is supposed to do. This has been highlighted below:
- **Better thesis - Private schools are generally more crowded than Government schools.** This thesis is good because it is focussed in that the writer is going to concentrate on the problem of overcrowding in private schools.

- **Too narrow a thesis – Mzuzu was declared a city in 1978.** This thesis is narrow in the sense that the writer is not given much room to flex the writing muscle. Obviously, it would be difficult to write more than two paragraphs on such a topic. It is a simple fact that does not require much support. Such a statement is sometimes called a *dead-end statement;* there is no place to go with it. This can be improved as below:
- **Better thesis-Mzuzu is Malawi's most expensive city.** This thesis is much better because if you were to write an essay, you would take a comparative approach which would give a lot of information.

2.1.2 Functions of the introduction

The introduction serves the following purposes:

- It attracts the reader's interest. The introductory paragraph should start with several sentences that attract the readers' attention and encourage them to continue reading the essay.
- It states the thesis statement. Here the introduction brings to light the thesis statement by advancing the thesis that will be developed in the essay and

sometimes it provides a plan of development or a preview of major points supporting the thesis.
- It leads the readers smoothly into the support paragraphs i.e. the body of the essay. These supporting paragraphs should be listed in the order in which they will appear in the essay.
- It supplies any background information that may be needed to understand the essay.

2.1.3 Types of introduction

When writing an essay, you are required to use any one method or a combination of methods, to introduce your subject in an interesting way to the readers.

- **A direct statement of the thesis statement**

With this introduction, you simply state the thesis statement directly. Attempt to give a preview of what your thesis is all about and how you will go about writing your essay.

- **Background information**

In this type, you give details about something. Make sure that you elaborate the way things are done or happen.

For instance, if you were to write an essay on problems faced by poorly established private schools, you could firstly provide information on how private schools came into being and what happens when people are opening private schools. This background information may set the platform that will be fully expounded in the body.

Example

Mzuzu University opened its doors in 1999 as the second public university in Malawi. Prior to that, there was only one university in Malawi. Mzuzu University was opened with the aim of training secondary school teachers.

- **Definition of terms**

In this type of introduction, writers can start their essay by firstly providing a definition for the most important terms in the thesis. For instance, if the essay is on impacts of deforestation, the writer might begin by providing a definition for the term deforestation. He or she may also go on to talk about causes of deforestation and this may act as a preview of what he or she will say in the body.

Example

Global warming is the rising of temperatures to the levels never experienced before that has made the earth much warmer than it used to be.

- **Use of a quotation**

Another method of introducing your essay is by using a quotation. This quotation can be something you have read in a book or article. It can also be something that you have heard: a popular saying or proverb, a current or recent advertising slogan, or a favourite expression used by friends or families. Using a quotation in your introductory paragraph lets you add someone else's voice to your own.

Example

According to Rubenstein "most developing countries are in danger of desertification due to tremendous pressure being exerted on forests due to rising populations".

- **Use a shocking statement**

You deliberately start with a startling fact that is aimed at raising curiosity in your readers. This will motivate your readers as they will want to find out more about the shocker that you have given them.

Example

If you wanted to attack private schools, you could start with a statement that may be bent at shocking your readers i.e. talking about lack of teaching and learning resources, immorality of the teachers and also absence of portable water and good toilet facilities.

- **Ask one or more questions**

Here you may ask a rhetorical question that simply wants the reader to think about possible answers, or you ask a question you intended to answer yourself later in the essay. For example, if you were to write a paper on love, you would come up with questions such as below:

"What is love? How do we really know that we are really in love? When we meet that special person, how can we tell that our feelings are genuine and not merely infatuation? And, if they are genuine, will these feelings last? Love…" (Langan, J. (2003) p. 89)

- **Use an incident or brief story**

Stories are naturally interesting. They appeal to a readers' curiosity. In your introduction, an anecdote will grab the readers' attention right away. The story should be brief and should be related to your main idea. The incident in the story can be something that happened to you; something you have heard about, or something you have read about in a newspaper or magazine.

Example

A couple of months ago, I was travelling to the Northern Region. I left Lilongwe early in the morning.

And as I drove, I kept looking sideways with an interest on our forests. My eyes didn't like what they saw. Most forests have been cleared and I was particularly touched by the way trees are being removed in Chikangawa Forest. The situation is very appalling. I met many trucks carrying timber and yet very little re-forestation is taking place. I felt like crying.

N.B. When developing an introduction, make sure that you do not use some mechanical methods (methods that are normal but just demonstrate the routine way of doing things which may sadly be boring because they have been used over and over again), which though simple and pretty effective, take away the interest in the readers' mind. In other words, mechanical introductions sound dry. Examples of mechanical introductions are:

- The purpose of this essay is to write about…
- I will now write a paper about…

The above examples need to be avoided, if not, make sure that you combine them with some better ways of introducing essays as we have discussed.

 **Activity 2**

Think about any topic and write an introduction using any one of the methods above.

2.4 The body

The body of an essay deals with supporting points that are developed in paragraphs. It is extremely important that you carefully choose material to be included in your essay. What you include in the body will be determined by the treatment of your thesis and it is advisable that you gather adequate information that best supports your essay before you actually take the trouble of starting developing your body.

When you are writing, your body each of the supporting paragraphs should begin with a topic sentence that states the point to be detailed in that paragraph.

- **Topic sentence**

A topic sentence is a key sentence that provides a focus for a supporting paragraph. The topic sentence is most often found at the beginning of a paragraph though occasionally it may feature in the middle or at the end of the paragraph. To fully understand the concept of topic sentence, read the essay below and answer questions that follow:

The hazards of movie-going

I am a movie fanatic. My friends count on me to know movie trivia and to remember every big Oscar awarded since I was in secondary school. My friends, though, have stopped asking me if I want to go out to the movies. While I love movies as much as ever, the inconvenience of going out, the temptations of the theatre, and the behaviour of some patrons are reasons for me to wait and rent the video.

To begin with, I just do not enjoy the general hassle of the evening. Since small local movie theatres are a thing of the past, I have to drive for fifteen minutes to get to the nearest multiplex. The parking lot is shared with several restaurants and a supermarket, so it's always jammed. I have to drive around at a snail's pace until I spot another driver backing out. Then it's time to stand in an endless line, with the constant threat that tickets for the show I want will sell out. If we do get tickets, the theatre will be so crowded that I won't be able to sit with my friends, or we'll have to sit in a front row gaping up at a giant screen. I have to shell out a ridiculous amount of money- up to $8 – for a ticket. That entitles me to sit while my shoes seal themselves to a sticky floor coated with spilled soda, bubblegum, and crushed raisins.

Second, the theatre offers tempting snacks that I really don't need. Like most of us, I have to battle an expanding waistline. At home, I do pretty well by simply not buying stuff that is bad for me. I can make do with snacks like celery and carrot sticks because there is no ice cream in the freezer. Going to the theatre, however, is like spending my evening in a Seven-Eleven that's been equipped with a movie screen and comfortable seats. As I try to persuade myself to just have a diet Coke, the smell of fresh popcorn dripping with butter soon overcomes me. Chocolate bars the sizes of small automobiles seem to jump into my hands. I risk pulling out my fillings as I chew enormous mouthfuls of Milk Duds. By the time I leave the theatre, I feel disgusted with myself.

Many of the other patrons are even more of a problem than the concession stand. Little kids race up and down the aisle, usually in giggling packs. Teenagers try to impress their friends by talking back to the screen, whistling, and making what they consider to be hilarious noises. Adults act as if they were at home in their own living room. They comment loudly on the ages of the stars and reveal plot twists that are supposed to be a secret until the film's end. And people of all ages create distractions.

They crinkle candy wrappers, stick gum on their seats, and drop popcorn tubs or cups of crushed ice and sodas on the floor. They also cough and burp, squirm endlessly in their seats.

(Adapted from Langan, J. (2003) College Writing Skills)



Activity 3

1 What is the topic sentence for the first supporting paragraph of the model essay?
The first topic sentence is then supported by the following details (fill in the missing details):
   a) Have to drive fifteen minutes
   b) _____
   c) Endless ticket line
   d) _____
   e) _____
   f) Sticky floor

2 What is the topic sentence for the second supporting paragraph of the essay?
The second topic sentence is then supported by the following details:
   a) At home, the only snacks are celery and carrot sticks.
   b) Theatre is like a Seven-Eleven with seats
   i) Fresh popcorn
   ii) _____
   iii) _____

3 What is the topic sentence for the third supporting paragraph of the essay?
The third topic sentence is then supported by the following details:
   a) _____
   b) _____
   c) _____
   d) _____

Based on the explanatory text and the activity, you should remember that the body of an essay has a topic sentence that is supported by some sentences found in the paragraph.

2.4.1 Methods of organising the body

You need to use some methods that help foster clarity and cohesion of your essay. You may use one or a combination of the following methods:

- **Using division of parts of a unit**

You must split your essay into different parts. You do this mainly by carefully analysing points that fully support your thesis. When you are certain, you are at liberty to divide the supporting points into different parts, i.e. first part, second part, third part etc. Once these divisions are made, you will develop your body part by part by initially tackling the first part and progress on chronologically.

This method is important as it enhances clarity, brevity and coherence in your essay.

- **Division of a process (explanation of how something is done)**

In this method, you take the trouble of explaining how something is executed. For example, if you were to write about how *nsima* is prepared, you would talk about all the processes involved from the moment the pot is cleaned through to the moment when the meal is ready for consumption. Conversely, if you were to write an essay about steps of doing a thing, you would write your essay by chronologically highlighting what happens at each stage or step. By doing this, your essay is going to demonstrate the highest degree of unity and coherence.

- **Using a narrative approach**

When you are writing your essay, using this approach, you write in a story telling manner. You tell about events that happen i.e. personal events, incidents or experiences.

When developing your body using this method, you may either use chronological order or flash-forwards and flashbacks. In chronological order, your essay starts at the beginning of a sequence of events and follows those events step by step until the conclusion. For example:

I had an important appointment in town yesterday, and I had planned to leave for the city at 2:30 p.m. I drove to Luwinga Filling Station with plenty of time to spare but then discovered that I had left my wallet in the office. I raced back to collect it unfortunately the road was very congested and I was forced to drive at a snail's pace. A five-minute journey took me almost fifteen minutes.

By the time I got back to the filling station, it was too late. My appointment was at 3 p.m. but I had not yet arrived to the venue. Though I finally got there, I was late by a good ten minutes.

The above example gives us clear details of how the above event unfolded. It starts from the beginning until the end. That is how you should write your essay when the narrative approach is used. On the other hand, use flash-forwards and flashbacks to create a special emphasis. A flash-forward is a device that you use to tell about an event before it actually happens. A flash-back tells about an event that happened at an earlier time. Look at the following illustration to appreciate how the flash-forward works:

When I stepped on the stage at the age of six to give my first violin recital, my heart was racing and the blood was pounding in my throat. I walked timidly to the centre of the stage, made a stiff bow, brought the instrument up to my shoulder, and started to play.

Had I been able to anticipate the thunderous applause that would greet me at the end of my performance, I would have been less nervous. My mother shouted "bravo" my father leapt to his feet and cheered, and my grandmother led the audience in a rousing display appreciation. There were calls for an encore, which I gladly granted.

But all that adulation had been far from my mind as I made those scratchy noises on my half-size violin. At the start of the recital, all I had wished was its conclusion.

(Adapted from Word-power 2, p. 217)

- **By using comparison and contrast**

You write your essay based on comparison and contrast. Comparison refers to statements of similarities between two or more related things and on the other hand, contrast refers to statements of differences between two or related things. What you do is to group together all similar points and those that are not similar. Sometimes you may synchronise points or ideas that are similar with those that are different in order to come up with a balanced argument.

- **By argumentation**

Here you write an essay by presenting an argument. You construct an argument by giving facts and examples; relate incidents and present opposing views. An effective argument must be supported by evidence. It is not enough to simply give an opinion. Sometimes in order to impress your readers, you can either put strong points first or end with weak points or vice versa. You may also advance arguments by looking at both sides of the coin that present both advantages and disadvantages. If you are interested in having a very sound argument, you may look at an idea from the left, centre and right. This will bring about an essay that encapsulates different facts and ideas that make your write up worthwhile and weighty.

2.5 The conclusion

This is a crucial part of the essay and it needs to be given all the time and effort. You do not have to rush otherwise; you will spoil all the good work you have done in the introduction and the body.

Make sure you impress your readers for the last time by writing a conclusion that is catchy. The concluding paragraph often summarises the essay briefly by restating the thesis and at times, the main supporting points. In addition, the writer often presents a concluding thought about the subject of the paper.

2.5.1 Functions of the conclusion

The conclusion performs the following functions:

- It satisfies the reader's interest that was aroused in the introduction. The conclusion should complement what the introduction does. The introduction arouses the reader's interest and the conclusion satisfies the reader. The introduction makes the reader curious, raises expectations in the reader concerning what the writer intends to do. The conclusion makes the reader feel that his/her expectations have been met. It makes the reader feel that the job the writer set out to do has indeed been completed.
- It reminds the reader about the thesis. As you close your essay, make sure that you touch on the thesis so that your reader can be reminded about the focus of your discussion.
- It provides the writer the last opportunity to impact on the readers' mind in order to create the desired effect on them. Make sure that you develop your conclusion in an enticing way so that you retain your readers' attention up to the last word of your essay and probably leave a life long impression on them.

2.5.2 Types of conclusion

In this section, we look at best methods of developing a conclusion. Any one of the ways below, or a combination of ways, may be used to round off your essay. What is important though is to see to it that your conclusion clearly relates to the thesis of your essay.

- **Conclude with a quotation**

You end on a high note if you choose a very good punch-line to conclude your essay. You must observe that the quotation you choose has some bearing on your thesis. It may not help matters choosing a quotation though good but very divergent from the thesis of your essay.

Example

In summary, it has been discussed that "deforestation is indeed a major problem in most developing countries and that unless something is done the entire Sub-Saharan Region will be a huge desert" (Banda, 2004 p. 34).

- **End with a summary and final thought**

Here you follow three classical steps of wrapping up your essay:

a) Tell them what you are going to tell them
b) Tell them
c) Tell them what you have told them

Steps (**a**) and (**b**) are executed in the introduction and body respectively. However, step (**c)** "Tell them what you have told them" is executed in the conclusion where you restate the thesis with supporting points. Don't use the exact wording you used before though.

Example
In this essay, we have been talking about deforestation. And as it has been highlighted, deforestation is more rampant in developing countries where among others things high population growth, urbanisation and need for settlement land are exerting pressure on the forests.

- **Conclude with a thought-provoking question or a series of questions**

Concluding with a question is another good way to successfully end your essay. A question tends to grab the reader's attention. It is a direct appeal to your reader to think further about what you have written. A question should follow logically from the points you have already made in the paper. Your question must deal with one of these areas:

a) Why the subject of your paper is important?
b) What might happen in the future?
c) What should be done about this subject?
d) Which choice should be made?

In your conclusion, you may provide an answer to your question. Be sure though, that the question is closely related to your thesis.

Example
In conclusion what is pollution? What causes pollution? What are the dangers of pollution and how can we avoid pollution?

- **Conclude with a call to action**

Here you may present a recommendation that asks your readers to do something. This will be in light of your thesis statement.

For instance, if you had been writing an essay on "poor educational standards in primary schools" you would ask your readers to embrace measures that will address this problem.

Example
It's now crystal clear that standards of education have gone low. We are now calling on the government and all stake holders to put mechanisms in place which will improve our educational standards as soon as possible.

- **Conclude with a summary of the main points**

This is one the easiest way of ending the essay. You just present a summary of what your essay has highlighted. In doing this, concentrate on main points and condense them in a manner that gives one a picture of what your essay is all about. Generally, this method is most appropriate for complex topics.

Example
This essay has highlighted four main causes for the decline in education standards. We have cited proliferation of private secondary schools, lack of well trained teachers, poor salaries and lack of learning and teaching materials. It has been suggested that unless these challenges are addressed, our education standards will keep on going down.

- **Conclude with a warning**

When using this method, make sure you present a sentence that sounds a warning.
It is particularly effective when you are writing on a subject that has social connotations. You structure your conclusion in such a way that the warning is clearly seen.

Example
HIV is real. If we do not change our attitudes we may all die.

- **Conclude with a restatement of the thesis**

This is another simple but effective way of ending your essay. You merely restate the thesis. Concluding thesis should be paraphrased in slightly different words from your earlier thesis. You should also aim at pointing at the significance of the thesis statement.

Example
From the overwhelming evidence provided in this essay, it can safely be said that abstinence is the only way of avoiding HIV and AIDS.

2.6 Stages in essay writing

2.6.1 Prewriting

Many people have trouble getting started with writing. You may not be able to think of an interesting topic or thesis. Or you may have trouble coming up with relevant details to support a possible thesis. Sometimes even after starting your essay, you may hit snags-moments when you wonder, "What else can I say?" or "Where do I go next?" The following pages describe stages or techniques that will help you think about and develop a topic and get words on a piece of paper: (1) brainstorming, (2) listing, (3) clustering, and (4) free writing.

- **Technique 1: Brainstorming**

In this technique, you ask the six big questions: Who? Where? When? Why? What? How? These questions will help you generate details for your topic. Asking questions can be an effective way of getting yourself to think about the topic from a number of different angles.

- **Technique 2: Listing**

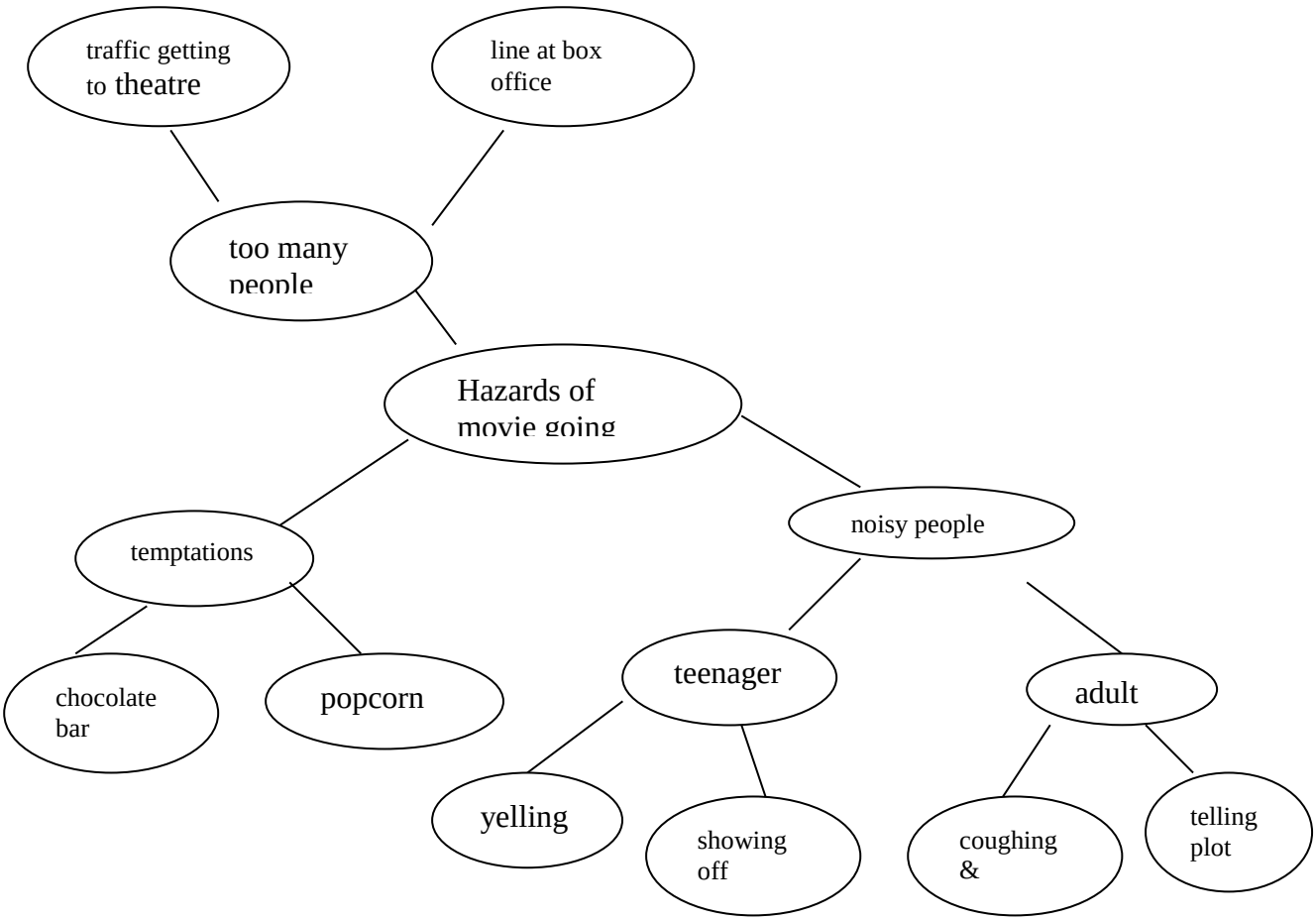
In this technique, you make a list. You collect a list of ideas and details that relate to your subject. Pile these items up, one after another randomly (without trying to sort out major details from minor ones or trying to put details in any special order). Your goal is just to make a list of everything about your subject that occurs to you.

- **Technique 3: Clustering**

This is also known as mind mapping or diagramming. This method is useful for people who like to do their thinking in a visual way. In clustering, you use lines, boxes, arrows, and circles to show relationships among the ideas and details that occur to you.

Begin by stating your subject in a few words in the centre of a blank sheet of paper. Then as ideas and details come to your mind, put them in boxes or circles around the subject and draw lines to connect them to each other and to the subject. Put minor ideas or details in smaller boxes or circles and use connecting lines to show how they relate as well. Keep in mind that there is no right or wrong way of diagramming or clustering. It is a way to think on paper about how various ideas and details relate to one another. Below is an example of how diagramming can be used:

Diagramming of hazards of movie going



- **Technique 4: Free-writing**

Free-writing means jotting down in rough sentences or phrases everything that comes to the mind about a possible topic. See if you can write non-stop for ten minutes or more. Do not worry about spelling or punctuating correctly, about erasing mistakes, about organising material, or about finding exact words. Instead, explore an idea by putting down whatever pops into your head. If you get stuck for words, repeat yourself until more words come. There is no need to feel inhibited, since mistakes *do not count* and you do not have to hand in your paper.

Free-writing will empower your writing muscles and make you familiar with the act of writing. It is a way to break through mental blocks about writing. Since you do not have to worry about mistakes, you can focus on discovering what you want to say about a subject. Your initial ideas and impressions will often become clear after you have gotten them down on paper and they may lead to other impressions and ideas.

2.6.2 Drafting your essay

When you have gathered your facts in the prewriting stage, it is now time to get started in writing your essay. The first step in this journey is by coming up with a draft where you prepare rough work. Drafting involves making preliminary version of your essay. In the first-draft stage, you want to get all your thoughts and ideas down on paper.

With your writing purpose, audience and method of development in mind, write your first draft fairly quickly. Do not stop to make corrections in such areas as spelling, grammar and punctuation as your main aim is to put your ideas on paper. The mistakes committed here will be rectified later on. As you develop your draft, make sure you stick closely to your outline otherwise if you do not then your piece of work lacks sound organisation.

2.6.3 Revising your essay

The literal meaning of revise is "to look again". Therefore, during revision you should see if you have said what you wanted to say and if you have said it clearly and effectively. Ensure that you take a careful look at the following: content (the material you have included in your essay i.e., is it suitable?); organisation i.e., has the material been well organised? and language i.e**.,** have you used language effectively- thus have you used the right words in the right manner?

Things to consider when revising

If you want to do a good job during revision then the following things have to be considered:

a) Coherence

This refers to the fitting together of all parts of the essay. It is important when you are writing to ensure that your essay clearly connects to the thesis. Coherence should also be achieved within and without a paragraph(s). This is attained by having sentences that proceed logically. Coherence can also be achieved by using transitional markers. Transitional or linking sentences are used between paragraphs to help tie together the supporting paragraphs in an essay. They enable the reader to move smoothly from one idea to another. Here are some examples of transitional words:

- **Addition signals:** one, first of all, second, the third reason, also, next, in addition, moreover, furthermore, finally, last of all
- **Time signals:** first, then, next, after, as, before, while, meanwhile, soon, now, during, finally
- **Space signals:** next to, across, on the opposite side, to the left, to the right, above, below near, nearby

- **Change of direction signals:** but, however, yet, in contrast, although, otherwise, still, on the contrary, on the other hand
- **Illustration signals:** for example, for instance, specifically, as an illustration, once, such as, to illustrate
- **Conclusion signals:** therefore, consequently, thus, then, as a result, in summary, to conclude, last of all, finally, in a nutshell, to sum up.

The above list is not exhaustive. You will come across many more transitional words. What is important though is to use them in your essays so as to achieve the coherence we are talking about. You can also achieve coherence by repeating key words in the preceding paragraph. What this entails is identifying key words in a paragraph and repeating them in the next paragraph. By doing this, you will allow for smooth transition from one paragraph to another.

b) Language

Another area that needs careful consideration when you are writing an essay is language. It is important to note that your essay is a formal document as such it must maintain formality. Always use formal language and never use any contracted versions of words. For instance, never write *can't* instead write *cannot.* You should also guard against use of slang language (these are very informal words and expressions that are more common in spoken language, especially used by a particular group of people). For example, words like "guys", "bucks" "buddies" etc should not find any place in your essay.

You should also avoid using clichés. As you may recall, a cliché is an expression that has lost its impact and meaning due to overuse. It may sound as a good expression but the fact that a myriad others have used it, renders it useless. More importantly, use of clichés undermines your creativity. Some examples of clichés include *last but not least* and *green with envy.*

c) Unity

An essay should show unity when all the components are related to the thesis statement or topic sentence. In other words, if you advance a single point and stick to that point, your essay will have unity. When writing make sure that all the material you include in your essay relates to the thesis. In addition, all the ideas in a paragraph should relate to the topic sentence. Avoid wandering off the topic.

To achieve unity, remove or rephrase all sentences that do not relate to the thesis and the topic sentence.

d) Support

Points advanced in your essay have to be supported with specific evidence. Make sure that the topic sentence of each paragraph is fully supported i.e. proved by adequate material such as examples and explanations. Do not just make an argument without any backing points. Also make sure that the treatment of your thesis is fully supported with materials it promises. You will recall that your thesis may state some points to be expounded in your body and when you are developing the body, ensure that this is done by providing as many facts as possible.

e) Sentences

Another way to demonstrate that you are a good writer is by writing good sentences. Good sentences are those that are free from errors and are composed in an especially impressive way. This is done by varying sentence lengths and sentence patterns. On sentence lengths, what you have to do is ensuring that your essay has both short and long sentences.

Short sentences are particularly useful when you are emphasising points or introducing ideas. No matter what, never confine yourself to one type of sentences but always blend. Remember variety is the spice of life.

Similarly, make sure that your sentence patterns are varied. It is important to see to it that your essay contains simple, compound, complex, and compound-complex sentences. Below is the meaning of these types of sentences:

Simple sentence: is a sentence that has only one main clause and no subordinate.

Examples: The boy ate the banana.
A man and his son watched the football match.

Compound sentence: is a sentence that has two or more main clauses and has no dependent clause.

Examples: John went to the market and James went to church.
The guests have no money; someone must lend them.

Complex sentence: is a sentence that has one main clause and one or more subordinate clauses.

Examples: Although I was sick, I still wrote the examination.
After I finished washing my clothes, I went to the library.

Compound - complex sentence: is a sentence that has more than one main clause and at least one subordinate clause.

Example: If we win this game, we will go to Lilongwe; if we won't, we will lose everything.

2.6.4 Editing your essay

After revising your essay, the last thing you have to do is to edit your work. In editing, you carefully examine what you have written. Look for mistakes in grammar, punctuation, capitalisation, omission (words mistakenly left out), spellings and tenses. The best way to do this is to read your essay aloud to yourself or better still give it to trusted friends who will help you identify the errors committed.



Activity 4

1 Why is a thesis important?
   a) Think of any topic and write a thesis statement.
   b) What type of approach have you used to develop the thesis?
2 Of the four stages in the essay writing process, which one appeals to you? Give reasons.
3 Define the term cliché.
   a) Write five examples of clichés.

2.7 Types of essays

In this last segment, we will look at how we can write different essays. Make sure you notice the distinct features in each type.

2.7.1 Expository essay

Expository essays are simply essays that explain something with facts, as opposed to opinion. Development of these essays centres on the 5W's and H writing style (use of who, what, why, when and how). As you write expository essays, make sure you present and explain information. Mostly, expository essays are written in response to questions that ask the writer to expose or explain a specific topic. These implied questions may include:

- Who or what is the person or thing under discussion?
- Why is the person or thing important?
- What does the person do?
- How does the thing work?
- When did the event take place? Etc.

A response to the above questions will yield:

- Essays that describe how to do something

- Essays that analyse events, ideas, objects, or written works
- Essays that explain/describe an historical event

As you write expository essays, make sure you are thorough enough and present sufficient information that fully explain the topic. Also bear in mind that expository essays should have the same basic structure as any typical essay. Theymust have an introduction, body and conclusion.

2.7.2 Descriptive essay

The word "description" means to narrate something in such a way that the reader is able to visualise the image that is portrayed. It also means to paint a word picture. In light of this, descriptive essays are those that say what somebody or something is like. A descriptive essay mirrors the mood of the writer and conjures images that breathe. It has the ability to transfer emotions to the reader through the use of words.

A good descriptive essay arouses and appeals to the reader's senses. The arousal is so powerful that it impacts on the reader's mind to evoke a correct response.

As you write descriptive essays, make sure that your description focuses on the most significant details about your subject. Do not waste time dealing with trivia stuff. Also use concrete language as opposed to abstract language. Let us now look at how we can use concrete language.

The word *happy* much as it shows someone's state is abstract. We need to use a concrete word like *laughing* which physically shows the happiness in an individual. Similarly avoid saying "She is *sad*" as the word "sad" is abstract. Instead use a more concrete word like "She is *sobbing"*.

2.7.3 Argumentative essay

This type of essay is also known as **persuasive.** It does not only give information but also presents an argument with the ***pros*** (supporting ideas) and *cons* (opposing ideas) of an argumentative issue. It may also dwell on arguing from as many different perspectives or viewpoints as possible.

In this type of essay, your primary objective is to convince your audience to agree with your facts, share your values, accept your argument and conclusion and adopt your way of thinking or point of view. To achieve this, make sure that you clearly take your stand and write in a persuasive manner. It is also important to ensure that you aim at convincing your reader to agree with your ideas or convince him or her to follow a particular course of action.

Organisation of an argumentative essay
An argumentative essay follows the basic principles of essay writing. Make sure you handle the entire essay parts well.

Introduction
Your introduction should provide background information on your topic or controversy and hook your reader's attention. This should end with a clear statement of your main idea or point of view.

Body paragraphs
Here is where you advance your argument in a convincing and persuasive manner. Make sure that your body paragraphs present the points in support of your main point or your viewpoint. Always support your views with sound reasons. It does not help matters merely giving opinions without substantiating them.

Ways of supporting an argument
You can support your arguments by using:

- *Facts-* this is a powerful means of convincing your readers. You can get facts from your reading, observation or personal experience.
- *Statistics-* these can provide excellent support to your essay. Be sure your statistics come from responsible sources and always cite your sources.
- *Quotes*-use of direct quotes from leading experts or authorities in support of your arguments is valuable.
- *Examples-* examples enhance your meaning and make your ideas concrete. They are also a proof of the validity of your arguments.

To make your argument prominent, start by presenting opposing views and then proceed to counter them. You can also either deal with less important points first and work up to serious ones later or reverse the procedure, discussing the serious ones first then tailing off into minor ones towards the end.

It is also imperative to provide a balanced argument. Make sure that you explore the weaknesses and bombard them with the merits from left, centre and right.

Make your meaning clear. Do not be vague because vagueness has no place in an argumentative essay. Be explicit and make sure that your reasons, facts and opinions are expressed in such a way that the reader does not ask about what you are trying to mean.

Conclusion

It is important to creatively restate your main argument and supporting points. Give a summary of your argument at the end by stating a course of action you feel the readers should take. Finally, try to leave your audience even more connected to your topic and persuaded by your main idea or perspective.

Patterns of organising argumentative essays

As you are aware, all argumentative topics have PROS and CONS. Before starting writing, it is imperative to make a list of these ideas and choose the most suitable ones among them for supporting and refuting. There are three possible organisation patterns:

Pattern 1

Thesis statement
PRO idea 1
PRO idea 2
CON(s) + Refutation(s)
Conclusion

Pattern 2

Thesis statement:

CON(s) + Refutation(s)
PRO idea 1
PRO idea 2
Conclusion

Pattern 3

Thesis statement:
CON idea 1 -----> Refutation
CON idea 2 -----> Refutation
CON idea 3 -----> Refutation
Conclusion



Activity 5

1 Using any two relevant points, compare and contrast expository and argumentative essays.
2 What does a descriptive essay do?
3 Some scholars have argued that there is a thin line between expository and argumentative essay. Why is this so?



Self assessment test

1 In your own words, define what an essay is.
2 Discuss why an introduction is one of the most important parts of your essay.
3 Mention any three methods of concluding your essay.
4 Of the three methods in (3) which, one in your opinion, is the best method? Provide reasons for your choice.
5 Think of any topic and identify the subject and the treatment.
6 Using your topic in (5) write an essay of not more than 300 words.
7 Why could division of essays into different types be merely a question of convenience than what the essays actually reveal on the ground?



Unit summary

In this unit, we have talked about what an essay is and how you can write it. If you may recall, we have said that an essay is a group of paragraphs that support a thesis. We have also highlighted some useful tips on how to get started and develop your essay in an impressive format that can fetch you good marks. Besides, we have analysed different types of essays you are likely to encounter in your academic work. It is our hope that you will be able to write good academic essays. In the next unit, we will talk about how you can maintain logic and sound reasoning as you advance your arguments.



References

Gallo, J & Rink, W. (1996) *Shaping College Writing: Paragraph and Essay.* New York: Harcourt Brace, Jovanovich.

Langan, J. (2003) *College Writing Skills, Media Edition.* New York: McGraw Hill.

Singleton, J. & Luckhurst, M. (2000) *The Creative Writing Handbook.* New York:Pal-grave.

Strong, W. & Lester, M., (Ed) (1996) *Writer's Choice: Grammar and Composition.* New York: McGraw Hill.